CIDS

TRAINING FRAMEWORK

1	**Consistency** Show Up	4x / week
2	**Intensity** Push Hard	<2 RIR
3	**Diet** Eat Right	1g/lb protein
4	**Sleep** Rest Well	7+ hrs / night

Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

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CONSISTENCY

#1: Consistency

Forget supplements. Forget meal timing. Forget the perfect program. None of it matters if you don't show up.

Exercise habits take about **91 days** to form — not 21. There's no shortcut. But here's the good news: your first 4 weeks predict everything. People who show up consistently in month one are **3x more likely** to stick with it long term.

The trick is to make it so easy you can't say no. Stack it onto something you already do — "After my morning coffee, I put on gym clothes." People who do this are 64% more likely to follow through. Don't rely on motivation. Make the decision once, then just follow the routine.

And focus on how it feels, not what it produces. If you enjoy it, you'll keep doing it. Results come from consistency, not from any single session.

Your target: 4x per week for 6 weeks

That's it. Don't optimize anything else until this is locked in.

> *"It's not what we do once in a while that shapes our lives, but what we do consistently." — Tony Robbins*

CONSISTENCY

Your 6-Week Consistency Ramp-Up

Target: 4x per week for 6 consecutive weeks

Week 1–2: Build the Trigger

- Pick 4 days and block them in your calendar as non-negotiable
- Create your habit stack: "After [morning coffee / finishing work], I [put on gym clothes]"
- Start tiny: 20 minutes is enough. The goal is showing up, not performance
- Track only one thing: did you go? Yes/No checkmark
- Reward yourself immediately after (favorite podcast, smoothie, whatever)
- If you miss a day: it's fine. Missing one day doesn't disrupt habit formation. But never miss twice — missing once is an accident, missing twice is the start of a new habit

Week 3–4: Build Automaticity

- Continue 4x/week — this is the critical formation window
- Extend sessions to your target duration (30–45 min)
- Add one new element per week to maintain novelty (different exercise, class, or equipment)

CONSISTENCY

Weeks 5–6: Lock It In

- At 42–49 days, research shows habit peaks for 48% of gym members
- Reduce decision-making: clothes laid out, bag packed, route automated
- Shift your identity: you're not "trying to exercise" — you're a person who exercises. Say it out loud. Tell people. This shift is what makes it permanent
- Plan for disruptions: what happens when you travel, get sick, have a bad day?
- If it still doesn't feel automatic, stay in this phase — don't rush to Intensity

CONSISTENCY

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Starting with 6 days/week (burns out by week 2)
- Focusing on the "perfect program" instead of just going
- Tracking performance metrics too early (track consistency, not weight/reps)
- Beating yourself up for missed days instead of returning the next day
- Trying to add diet/sleep changes simultaneously

Graduation Checklist

Move to Intensity when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You've completed 4x/week for 6 consecutive weeks
- ☐ Going to the gym feels automatic, not like a decision
- ☐ Missing a session feels wrong, not like a relief
- ☐ You have a consistent time and trigger that works
- ☐ You can handle schedule disruptions without falling off

2

INTENSITY

PUSH HARD

INTENSITY

#2: Intensity

You're showing up — good. But are you actually working? Most people aren't. Same weight for months, phone between sets, and wondering why nothing changes.

When you think you've hit failure, your muscles can still produce **3x the power** required. Your brain quits long before your body does. Beginners have **4–5 extra reps** left when they think they're done. That gap is the difference between coasting and growing.

Discomfort tolerance is trainable — it's practice, not genetics. Use self-talk on hard reps ("You've got this, two more") — it improves endurance by 18%. Focus into the sensation instead of distracting yourself. The discomfort is the stimulus.

Your target: finish every working set within 0–2 reps of failure

If you could have done 3 more, it wasn't hard enough.

INTENSITY

Your 4-Week Intensity Ramp-Up

Target: Train at 0–2 RIR on all working sets

Week 1: Calibration

- On the LAST set of each exercise, go to actual failure (safely, with a spotter or on machines)
- Count how many reps beyond your normal stopping point — this reveals your hidden reserve (typically 3–8 reps)
- Record your estimated RIR vs actual for each exercise
- Continue 4x/week schedule from Phase 1
- This week is data collection, not ego — use moderate weights

Week 2: Close the Gap (target 2–3 RIR)

- Use Week 1 data to recalibrate — add reps or weight to reach the 2–3 RIR zone
- Begin motivational self-talk on the final 3–5 reps ("You've got this, two more")
- Phone stays in the bag during all working sets
- Continue last-set-to-failure on one exercise for ongoing calibration

INTENSITY

Intensity Ramp-Up: Weeks 3–4

Week 3: Normalize Discomfort (target 1–2 RIR)

- Increase load ~5% on compound lifts OR add 1–2 reps per set
- At least 2 sets per exercise should finish at 1 RIR
- Practice associative focus: stay with the sensation instead of escaping it
- Pre-commit to rep targets BEFORE the set — no mid-set negotiation
- Use short cue words per rep: "Drive," "Push," "One more"

Week 4: Full Intensity (target 0–2 RIR)

- Working sets: ~30% to failure, ~50% at 1 RIR, ~20% at 2 RIR
- Self-talk and associative strategies should feel habitual
- What felt like RPE 9 in Week 1 should feel like 7–8 at the same load — your tolerance has grown

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Ego lifting — heavy weight with bad form is not intensity, it's injury risk
- Junk volume — 20 sets at RIR 5 is worse than 10 sets at RIR 1–2
- Not tracking weights/reps — you can't know if you're progressing without data
- Going too heavy too fast — build intensity gradually over 4 weeks, not overnight
- Confusing soreness with effectiveness — DOMS ≠ growth stimulus

Graduation Checklist

Move to Diet when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You consistently train at 0–2 RIR on working sets
- ☐ You can accurately estimate your RIR within 1–2 reps
- ☐ You log your weights and reps every session
- ☐ Discomfort during hard sets feels manageable, not terrifying
- ☐ You've been training at this intensity for at least 4 weeks

DIET

#3: Diet

You're consistent and training hard. Now give your body what it needs to actually build. The answer is simpler than the fitness industry wants you to believe: protein.

Not a special diet. Not intermittent fasting. Not cutting carbs. Just enough protein, every single day. A review of 49 studies confirmed it — total daily protein is the single strongest predictor of muscle gains. Timing doesn't matter. Supplements don't matter. Just hit your number.

Spread it across 4 meals — about 30g each. Distributing protein evenly produces **25% more** muscle protein synthesis than loading it all at dinner.

Your target: 1g per pound of bodyweight (2g/kg) per day

If you weigh 180 lbs, eat 180g of protein. Split across 4 meals, that's ~45g each.

> *"You don't do things right once in a while. You do things right all the time." — Vince Lombardi*

DIET

Your Protein Cheat Sheet

How Much You Need

Your Weight	Daily Target	Per Meal (4 meals)
130 lb / 59 kg	130g	~33g
150 lb / 68 kg	150g	~38g
180 lb / 82 kg	180g	~45g
200 lb / 91 kg	200g	~50g

Where To Get It

Build every meal around one of these. A palm-sized portion is roughly 30g.

Chicken breast (6 oz)	54g	Eggs (3 large)	18g
Greek yogurt (1 cup)	20g	Whey protein (1 scoop)	25g
Tuna (1 can)	30g	Cottage cheese (1 cup)	28g
Ground beef (6 oz)	42g	Tofu, firm (1 cup)	20g

DIET

Your 4-Week Protein Ramp-Up

Target: Hit your daily protein goal 5 out of 7 days

Week 1: Awareness

- Track everything you eat for 7 days (MyFitnessPal, notebook, photos — whatever works)
- Don't change anything — just observe
- At the end of the week, calculate your average daily protein
- Most beginners discover they're eating 60–80g when they need 150–180g
- The gap is your roadmap

Week 2: Fix Breakfast

- Breakfast is the biggest protein gap for most people (toast, cereal, fruit = near-zero protein)
- New default: 30–40g protein at breakfast (eggs + Greek yogurt, protein shake + oats, etc.)
- Pick 2–3 breakfast options and rotate — don't overthink it
- Continue tracking protein only (not calories, carbs, or fat)

DIET

Protein Ramp-Up: Weeks 3–4

Week 3: Fix Lunch + Dinner

- Anchor every meal around a protein source FIRST, then add everything else
- Simple rule: palm-sized portion of protein at every meal = roughly 30g
- Add a 4th protein hit if needed (pre-bed Greek yogurt, protein shake, cottage cheese)
- You should be hitting your target most days now

Week 4: Fine-Tune and Automate

- Review your tracking: hitting 5/7 days at target?
- Identify your go-to meals — the 5–6 meals you rotate through that always hit protein
- Start meal prepping: 2 hours on Sunday saves you all week
- Stop obsessive tracking — you know your defaults now, trust them
- Only re-track if you change your routine significantly

DIET

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Overthinking it — protein first, the rest follows
- Relying entirely on shakes (whole food protein is more satiating)
- Undercounting: not weighing/measuring initially, then overestimating
- Trying to overhaul everything at once (just fix protein, not your entire diet)
- Skipping meals then trying to get 100g at dinner

Graduation Checklist

Move to Sleep when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You know your daily protein target and can hit it 5/7 days
- ☐ You have 5–6 default meals that reliably hit 30g+ protein each
- ☐ You can eyeball a protein portion without weighing it
- ☐ Breakfast includes 30g+ protein as a habit
- ☐ You've maintained this for at least 3 consecutive weeks

SLEEP

#4: Sleep

You're doing the work. You're eating right. Now let your body rebuild. Muscle isn't built in the gym — it's built while you sleep. 70% of daily growth hormone is released during deep sleep. Cut your sleep short and you're cutting your gains.

One bad night reduces muscle protein synthesis by **18%** and spikes cortisol by 21%. If you're in a deficit and undersleeping, you may be losing muscle instead of fat.

The biggest factor isn't total hours — it's **regularity**. Consistent schedules matter more than duration. Same bedtime, same wake time, even weekends. For most people that's 10pm–midnight. Going to bed at 2am once every two weeks is fine. Doing it three times a week is sabotaging your gains.

Your target: 7+ hours every night, same schedule 7 days a week

Build a shutdown ritual — brush teeth, hot shower, book. The sequence signals your brain that sleep is coming.

> *"Hard work, dedication, and discipline separate the best from the rest." — Kobe Bryant*

SLEEP

What Actually Works

Ranked by strength of evidence. Start from the top.

1. Consistent schedule — same wake time every day, even weekends. This is the single most impactful change you can make.

2. Caffeine cutoff — caffeine steals 45 minutes of sleep and 11 minutes of deep sleep. No coffee after 2pm. No pre-workout after noon.

3. Cool, dark room — 18–21°C / 65–70°F. Blackout curtains or a sleep mask.

4. Phone in another room — not on silent, not face-down. In another room. Charging.

5. Protein before bed — 30–40g of protein before sleep gives your body the raw materials to build muscle overnight.

SLEEP

Your 4-Week Sleep Ramp-Up

> **Target: 7+ hours of consistent, quality sleep per night**

Week 1: Assess + Caffeine Fix

- Track your sleep for 7 days: what time you go to bed, what time you wake up, how you feel (1–5)
- Calculate your average — most people discover they're getting 5.5–6.5 hours
- Implement caffeine cutoff: no coffee/pre-workout after 2pm (or 9 hours before target bedtime)
- This one change alone can add 30–45 minutes of quality sleep
- Don't change anything else yet

Week 2: Anchor Your Wake Time

- Pick a wake time and stick to it 7 days a week — yes, weekends too
- This is more important than bedtime — regularity drives sleep quality more than total hours
- Your body will naturally start getting tired earlier once the wake time is consistent
- Continue tracking sleep hours and quality rating
- Expect the first few days to feel rough if your weekend wake time was 2+ hours later

Week 3: Optimize Environment + Set Bedtime

SLEEP

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Sleeping in on weekends (destroys regularity — the single most important factor)
- "I'll sleep when I'm dead" mentality (sleep deprivation literally reduces muscle growth by 18%)
- Relying on supplements (melatonin masks the problem, doesn't fix it)
- Screen time in bed (the bed is for sleep, not scrolling)
- Ignoring caffeine timing (that 3pm coffee is costing you 45 minutes of sleep)

Graduation Checklist

You've completed CIDS when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You average 7+ hours of sleep per night
- ☐ Your bedtime and wake time are consistent within 30 minutes, 7 days/week
- ☐ You fall asleep within 15–20 minutes of lying down
- ☐ You wake up feeling functional without hitting snooze
- ☐ You've maintained this for at least 3

Your CIDS Timeline

The full journey — 18 weeks to lock in all four

WEEKS 1–6

Consistency — Show Up

Build the gym habit. 4x per week, every week. Start small. Track attendance only. Don't optimize anything yet — just show up until it's automatic.

WEEKS 7–10

Intensity — Push Hard

Calibrate your effort. Learn to train at 0–2 RIR. Close the gap between perceived and actual failure. Build discomfort tolerance through practice.

WEEKS 11–14

Diet — Eat Right

Nail your protein. Track for a week, fix breakfast, fix lunch and dinner, then automate. 1g per pound, 30g+ per meal, 5/7 days on target.

WEEKS 15–18

Sleep — Rest Well

Optimize recovery. Cut caffeine early, anchor your wake time, set your environment, fine-tune. 7+ hours, consistent schedule, 7 days a week.

After Week 18, you have all four pillars in place.

Now it's maintenance. Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

Key principle: Don't skip ahead. Each pillar

Quick Reference Card

Screenshot this page or print it

	Target	Key Rule
Consistency	4x / week	Show up before you optimize
Intensity	<2 RIR	Your brain quits before your body does
Diet	1g/lb / 2g/kg protein	Total daily protein is all that matters
Sleep	7+ hrs / night	Regularity beats duration

Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

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All research cited in this guide — tap to read the full study

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